GLOBAL MENTORSHIP INITIATIVE

Session 5 – Student Guide

Professional Skills Development



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Professional Skills to Succeed

Companies are looking for job candidates who possess a balance of both soft and hard skills.

Soft Skills

- ✓ Soft skills are the transferable skills that can be used regardless of the position you hold in a company.
- ✓ Companies prefer job candidates with these transferable skills because the employees can grow into new roles and handle any challenges that come up as the company requirements change.
- ✓ Soft skills are personal attributes and personality traits:

- Communication Ability
- Creative Thinking
- Time Management
- Decision Making
- Problem-Solving
- Listening Skills
- Work Ethic
- Conflict Resolution
- Motivating Others'
- Critical Thinking
- Empathy
- Flexibility
- Networking
- Teamwork

Hard Skills

- ✓ Hard skills refers to the skills required for a specific job.
- ✓ Businesses will typically list the required hard skills for a position in the 'Required Skills' or 'Desired Skills' section of the job description.
- ✓ Below are a few examples of common hard skills desired by companies:

- Analysis
- Editing
- Project Management
- Reporting
- Testing
- Computer Languages
- Financial Skills
- Medical
- Science
- Translation
- Design
- Information Technology
- Research
- Teaching
- Writing

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Professionalism in the Workplace

Professionalism encompasses everything from the way you dress to the way you communicate with peers. Your degree of professionalism will affect your promotability.

Dress

Dress one level more polished than what's expected. It shows intention and professionalism without overdoing it. Dress neatly, even in a workplace with a casual dress code. Casual is ok, but not sloppy.

Behavior

Your workplace behavior should be confident, not arrogant.
Be polite to everyone, especially during tense situations.
Be conscious of your body language to make sure it conveys the message you intend others to receive.

Be Realistic

Commit to what you realistically can do and then do it. If you are being asked to achieve a goal you think is not possible, calmly describe the obstacles and then look for ways the team can overcome them.

Ethics

Always maintain your personal code of ethics.

Poise

Maintain your poise. If you keep a professional demeanor when facing difficult situations, your team will look to you as an example.

Communication

Your email correspondence should be brief, polite, and to the point. Long emails are seldom read in their entirety.

Organization

Maintain structure and organization in your workspace. Being organized tells your employer and colleagues you are competent and in control of your work environment.

Responsibility

If you make a mistake, own up to it. This will increase your credibility with colleagues. If your work team makes a mistake, publicly own your share of the blame.

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Creating SMART Goals for Your Career

S	Specific	Be as specific as possible when creating goals
M	Measurable	There should always be a way to measure your goal
A	Attainable	Make sure your goal is realistic and achievable
R	Relevant	This specific SMART goal should align with your overall career goals
T	Timely	Set a specific date or time frame that you would like to complete your goal



Why Use SMART Goals

SMART goals keep you on track to completing your overall career objectives by creating realistic, measurable steps and preventing procrastination.

How to Use SMART Goals

1. Determine a career goal that relates to your overall career path.
2. Outline the tasks needed to complete your overall career goal.
3. Fill in the sections of the SMART Goals Worksheet for each task.
4. Combine all the categories to create your SMART goal.
5. Start working towards your goal!

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Creating SMART Goals

Specific

When creating your SMART goal, try answering the 5 W's: who, what, where, when, and why.

- ✓ Who: refers to anyone that is needed to help complete this goal.
- ✓ What: refers to the task that you want to complete through this goal.
- ✓ Where: if there is a relevant location to your goal.
- ✓ When: covered in the "Time-Bound" section of your SMART goal.
- ✓ Why: why do you want to complete this goal?

Measurable

- ✓ Your goal should have a metric in which you can track your progress.
- ✓ This does not have to be a numerical value, just something that can show you are on track to completing your goal.
- ✓ Think about what the successful completion of your goal will look like and that will be your way of measuring your goal.

Attainable

- ✓ Your goal should be realistic for you to achieve.
- ✓ This step allows you to analyze what you will need to complete your goal.
- ✓ If there are skills and tools that you currently do not have, then create steps to attain them.

Relevant

- ✓ This task should be relevant to the overall career goal you are working to reach.
- ✓ Understanding the relevance of your SMART goal will help you better prioritize your tasks.
- ✓ If this goal is not helping you get closer to your overall career goal, is it worth your time and effort?

Timely

- ✓ Set a specific date to complete your goal by, or a specific time frame in which you want to complete your goal to help define the amount of time you must have to complete a task.
- ✓ Creating a "due date" will help you prioritize the smaller tasks you need to get done to complete the overall SMART goal.
- ✓ Having a "due date" will also prevent you from procrastinating on completing your goal.

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Examples of SMART Goals

College Students

✓Look at job listings for my industry online to better understand the skills and qualifications required and what positions are available for at least five hours per week until graduation.

✓Create my professional resume and have at least two career professionals look over the rough draft and provide feedback by one month from now.

✓Expand my professional network by spending at least one hour per week developing my LinkedIn account, adding my professional skills, and making connections with colleagues by graduation.

Early Career Professionals

✓ Enhance my interview skills by practicing writing STAR responses to common behavioral interview questions for at least two hours per week for the next two months, or until I accept a job offer.

✓ Increase my professional network by sending at least two emails requesting informative interviews from career professionals in my field per week until I have at least 50 new professional connections in my LinkedIn network.

✓ Deepen my understanding of marketing by reading at least one journal per week related to the marketing field for the next two months.

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AI Questions / Queries

AI Questions for Professional Skills

- ✓ What soft skills are required to be a good business development manager in the software industry?
- ✓ How can I demonstrate empathy in the workplace?
- ✓ What certifications do I need to be a primary school teacher in <country>?

AI Questions for Professional Skills

- ✓ Help me create a SMART goal for becoming a software engineer within three years.
- ✓ Write a SMART goal for achieving a 20% increase in sales for my product within 18 months.





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Further Discussion

Questions to Ask Your Mentor

- ✓ What types of professional development have you done?
- ✓ Does your company offer professional development opportunities?
- ✓ If my career requires additional education, what work can I do without the additional education?
- ✓ If no further training is advised, what positions do you recommend shadowing to learn more about the field?
- ✓ Are there free options for certifications? Trainings? If so, where can I find them?

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Action Items Before Next Session

Before Session 6

- ✓ Complete the “Build a Career Plan” and “Career Path Exploration” worksheets prior to your next session

- ✓ Mark Session 5 as complete on the Student Portal

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- ‘Set SMART. Goals to Succeed’ – Ohio Health Blog https://blog.ohiohealth.com/set-smart-goals-succeed/

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- ‘SMART. Goals: A How To Guide’ – University of California https://www.ucop.edu/local-human-resources/_files/performance-appraisal/How%20to%20write%20SMART%20Goals%20v2.pdf

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